PASSATELLI IN BRODO

REGION	SERVES	TOTAL TIME
North	**4-6**	**5 h**

INGREDIENTS

456 g	Country bread, torn into pieces
214 g	Parmigiano-reggiano for the dough, finely grated
300 g	Eggs
quantity not given	Nutmeg, whole
1 lemon	Lemon peel, pith removed and finely chopped
1.6 to 1.8 kg	Chicken
2.8 to 4.7 kg	Water
300 g	Carrots, peeled and cut into 1-inch pieces
370 g	Onion, cut into quarters
227 g	Celery, cut into 1-inch pieces
150 g	Leek, cut into 1-inch pieces
30 g	Parsley
100 g	Garlic, cut in half
9 g	Black peppercorns
1	Bay leaf, fresh
quantity not given	Salt
22 g	Parmigiano-reggiano to finish, finely grated

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 200°F.
2. Spread the torn bread on a sheet pan and bake it 30 to 45 minutes, until dried out with no color on it. To test, smash a shard with the back of a spoon — the interior has to be bone dry. Let it cool.
3. Pulse the cooled bread in a food processor to a very fine, uniform crumb. Weigh out 230 g of crumbs for the dough. The rest keeps 2 weeks in an airtight container somewhere cool and dry.
4. Stir the 230 g of crumbs together with the 214 g of parmigiano. Tip the mixture onto a wooden work surface and open a well in the middle.
5. Whisk the eggs quickly in a small bowl, then whisk in 35 to 40 gratings of nutmeg and the chopped lemon peel.
6. Pour half the egg mixture into the well. Draw the inner wall of crumbs and cheese in with a fork, working continuously around the circumference. Add the rest of the egg and carry on the same way.
7. Once it has come together as a mass, knead gently, just to unify it. The dough wants to be firm enough to hold its shape but soft enough to pass through a potato ricer or passatelli press without a fight. Shape it into a ball, cover with plastic wrap and rest it at least 1 hour. To form it that evening or the next day, refrigerate the dough and take it out 20 to 30 minutes before you shape. Use it within 24 hours.
8. Put the chicken in a large stockpot with 2.8 kg of the water. If it is not submerged, add more water to cover it by 3 inches. Over low heat, bring it slowly up to a simmer, 45 minutes to 1 hour. Scum will start to rise as soon as it simmers. Skim it off as it comes, using a large spoon, so the brodo stays very clear.
9. If the level drops below the chicken after an hour, add more water to re-cover it and simmer 2 hours longer, still skimming and still topping up so the bird stays covered.
10. At the 3-hour mark, add the onion, carrots, celery, leek, garlic, parsley, peppercorns and bay leaf. Hold at a slow simmer another 1 to 2 hours, until the broth tastes strongly of itself.
11. Line a fine-mesh strainer with cheesecloth, or with a coffee filter, and pass the brodo through it. Measure 1.4 kg into a large sauce pot. Cool the rest and keep it in an airtight container, refrigerated up to 5 days or frozen. Refrigerate the chicken meat for another use.
12. Set the sauce pot of brodo over medium heat, bring it to a gentle simmer and season with salt.
13. Fit a potato ricer with the medium die.
14. Quarter the dough. Load one quarter into the ricer chamber and squeeze the handles together directly over the brodo, cutting the strands to 2 or 3 inches with a knife as they extrude. Work through the other three quarters the same way, dropping each batch into the pot.
15. Cook the passatelli slowly in the brodo until they float to the surface, 2 to 3 minutes.
16. Ladle into bowls and finish with the 22 g of parmigiano and grated nutmeg.

NOTES

The name means "to be passed through". The dough goes through il ferro, the iron made for the job, or a potato ricer on the medium die.
Texture is the whole test. Too soft and they disintegrate as they hit the brodo, too firm and they hold their shape without swelling like a sponge.
Dry the bread without letting it take any color, and crush a shard to check the inside is dry right through before you grind it.
Traditional versions enrich the crumb and cheese base with bone marrow or minced salumi or mortadella. Pepper and nutmeg are standard. Lemon zest is the Umbrian and Marchigiana addition.
The brodo makes more than the dish needs. 1.4 kg goes into the pot and the rest keeps 5 days refrigerated or freezes.

DATE ____ / ____ / ____ RATING ____ / 5 OVEN ADJ _____

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